

Religion establishes the beliefs and rituals surrounding the sacred and provides meaning and significance to individuals' lives. The tenets of any given religion can have a far-reaching impact on the individuals within its faith community. For example, certain religions promote faith-based lifestyle directives (FBLDs), which urge believers to follow specific guidelines regarding their own behavior (eg, restrictions on diet and substance use) and their treatment of others (eg, mission work). Because these practices typically reflect the religious group's values, FBLDs are often an important expression of faith for the deeply religious.

One religious group with health-related FBLDs is the Seventh Day Adventist Church, which formed in the 1860s after early leaders broke away from established Protestant churches. Since its formal establishment, Seventh Day Adventist Church membership has grown from 3,500 to over 20 million worldwide. The Seventh Day Adventist Church advocates conservative religious teachings and a holistic approach to health and wellness; members are encouraged to pursue vegetarianism, exercise regularly, and avoid alcohol and tobacco.

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Researchers from a variety of fields have examined health-related religious values and FBLDs. Epidemiological research has shown that believers from different religions who follow certain FBLDs (eg, abstaining from smoking and alcohol) experience lower rates of chronic illnesses (eg, heart disease and many types of cancer) than the general population. Sociologists have suggested that as a society increasingly relies on medical professionals, rather than clergy, as legitimate sources of guidance on lifestyle behaviors, membership in religious groups with values that are compatible with medicalization will continue to rise. Some hypothesize that this phenomenon accounts for the seemingly contradictory increase in

membership in certain conservative religious groups with strict FBLDs, despite mainstream society becoming less religious.

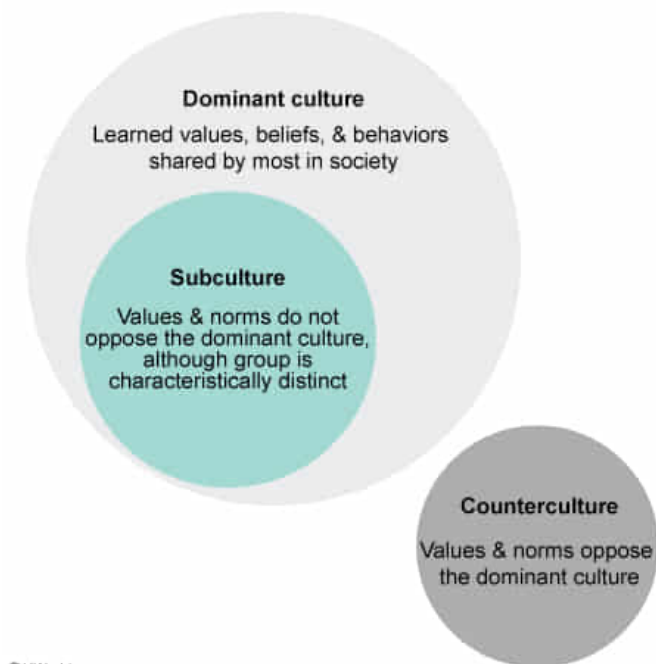
The sects and churches with FBLDs described in the passage are most likely to be categorized as:

- ☐ A. countercultures, because members' values and norms oppose those of mainstream society. [7%]
- ☐ B. utilitarian organizations, because membership is voluntary and based on shared values. [28%]
- ☒ C. subcultures, because members' values and norms are distinct from mainstream society. [48%]
- ☐ D. aggregates, because membership is based on a sense of unity and identification with the group. [14%]

Correct

48% answered correctly

Explanation:



Religious organizations can be categorized as churches, sects, and cults.

- **Churches** are **established** formal organizations that tend to be well integrated into society.
- **Sects** are formed after believers **split from** an **established church**,

often in pursuit of a **more pure** or traditional form of faith.

- **Cults** are **radical** groups of believers organized around a **charismatic leader**.

The dominant culture includes the established set of norms, values, and beliefs that define a society. A **subculture** is a group of individuals who are characteristically **distinct** from the dominant culture, but whose values and norms **still generally align** with the dominant culture.

The sects and churches described in the passage have values and norms (eg, FBLDs) that differ somewhat (ie, are distinctive) from mainstream society, but that are not opposed to it; therefore, they would best be categorized as *subcultures*.

(Choice A) A counterculture *opposes* and *rejects* the norms/values of the dominant culture (eg, much of the antiwar movement of the 1960s). The sects and churches described in the passage are *distinct* from mainstream culture, but there is no indication that they are *opposed* to it, making them subcultures, not countercultures.

(Choice B) Utilitarian organizations compensate members for their involvement (eg, money, certification/diploma). The sects and churches described in the passage could be considered *normative organizations* (ie, membership based on shared values), not utilitarian organizations.

(Choice D) An aggregate is a collection of individuals who share a common location but do not identify as a group (eg, all the people at a given store at 11:00 AM). The sects and churches described in the passage could be considered *in-groups* (ie, groups to which members identify and belong), not aggregates.

Educational objective:

A subculture is distinct from the dominant culture but is still aligned with the general norms and values of the dominant culture.

Time spent: 0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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Based on the passage, which statement is most consistent with a symbolic interactionist perspective?

- ☐ A. The definition for what is sacred may differ depending on the religion. [20%]
- ☐ B. Dynamic equilibrium is maintained when social control gradually shifts from religion to medicine. [4%]
- ☒ C. Individuals create meaning through serving others in faith-based mission work. [70%]
- ☐ D. Some religious groups attempt to reduce health care disparities that stem from class inequalities. [4%]

Correct

69% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major theoretical approaches to sociology			
Theory	Description	Perspective	Theorists
Functionalism	- Society = an organism - Each part of society works to maintain dynamic equilibrium (homeostasis)	Macro	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons
Conflict	- Society = struggle for limited resources - Inequality based on social class	Macro	Karl Marx, Max Weber
Social constructionism	- Social actors define what is real - Knowledge about world based on interactions	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)
Symbolic interactionism	- Meaning & value attached to symbols - Individual interactions based on these symbols	Micro	Charles Cooley, George Herbert Mead
Rational choice/social exchange	Individual behaviors & interactions attempt to maximize personal gain & minimize personal cost	Micro	(Not critical for exam)
Feminist	Examines gender inequality in society	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)

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Symbolic interactionism is a micro-sociological perspective concerned with the **interpersonal interactions** through which the **subjective meanings** that shape social **reality** are developed. Subjective meanings differ by context and culture (eg, avoiding eye contact is a sign of respect in Japan but is considered rude in the US) and can change over time.

The statement that individuals *create meaning* through serving (ie, interacting with) others in faith-based mission work is most consistent with symbolic interactionism. Under the symbolic interactionist perspective, mission work may become a meaningful expression and symbol of a believer's faith.

(Choice A) Social constructionism suggests that reality is created through shared meanings and definitions arising from social interactions. A definition for what is sacred that depends on the religion reflects a perspective that is most consistent with *social constructionism* (not symbolic interactionism).

(Choice B) Structural functionalism emphasizes how social structures maintain dynamic equilibrium (ie, homeostasis) in society. The maintenance of dynamic equilibrium through the gradual shifting of social control from religion to medicine reflects a *functionalist* (not symbolic interactionist) perspective.

(Choice D) Conflict theory focuses on how inequalities between social classes cause conflict. A situation in which religious groups attempt to reduce health care disparities that stem from class inequalities aligns with a *conflict* (not symbolic interactionist) perspective.

Educational objective:

Symbolic interactionism is a micro-sociological perspective that suggests that people develop subjective meanings for things (eg, objects, behaviors) through social interaction.

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Behavioral Sciences

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System:

Demographics and Social Structure

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Which concept is most relevant to the hypothesis described at the end of the fourth paragraph?

✔ ☒ A. Secularization [61%]

- ☐ B. Cultural transmission [27%]
- ☐ C. McDonaldization [3%]
- ☐ D. Social reproduction [7%]

Correct

60% answered correctly

Explanation:

Religion & social change	
Modernization	Reduced importance of religion as society industrializes
Secularization	Reduced power of religion as religious involvement declines
Fundamentalism	Renewed commitment to traditional religion as a reaction to secularization

Major types of **social change** can affect a society's emphasis on religion:

- **Modernization** refers to the **social progress** and **transition** of a **society** brought about by industrialization. This process results in a society becoming less traditional and more bureaucratized, with a reduction in the importance of religion.
- As religious involvement declines, **secularization** of a society occurs as **religious institutions lose** social and political **influence**.
- A reaction to secularization, **fundamentalism** refers to the **renewed** adherence to strict, **traditional religious beliefs** and practices by some individuals.

According to the fourth paragraph, some sociologists hypothesize that the seemingly contradictory increase in the membership of some conservative religious groups despite mainstream society becoming less religious (ie, more secularized) is occurring because the values of these religious groups are compatible with medicalization (a more secular value). Therefore, this hypothesis is most relevant to *secularization*.

(Choice B) Cultural transmission describes the passing of cultural elements (material, nonmaterial, or both) from one generation to the next. The contradiction described by the hypothesis is most consistent with secularization, not cultural transmission.

(Choice C) McDonaldization describes the process by which extreme efficiency and rationalization produce negative consequences in society (eg, reduced quality of products). The contradiction described by the hypothesis is most consistent with secularization, not McDonaldization.

(Choice D) Social reproduction refers to the transmission of society's values, norms, and practices, including social inequality, from one generation to the next (eg, the child of wealthy parents tends to be wealthy as an adult). The contradiction described by the hypothesis is most consistent with secularization, not social reproduction.

Educational objective:

Modernization, the transition of a society due to industrialization, results in religion losing importance in society. Secularization refers to the diminishing social/political influence of religion in society. A reaction to secularization, fundamentalism refers to renewed adherence to strict, traditional religious beliefs/practices by some individuals.

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Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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Results from a survey of believers indicated a positive correlation between the incorporation of religion into an individual's life and participation in FBLDs. This illustrates what type of study, and what concept was being assessed?

- ☐ A. Observational, religious affiliation [29%]
- ☐ B. Experimental, religious affiliation [6%]
- ✓ ☒ C. Observational, religiosity [56%]
- ☐ D. Experimental, religiosity [6%]

Correct

57% answered correctly

Explanation:

In sociology, there is a distinction between religiosity and religious affiliation. **Religiosity** refers to the extent to which a religious doctrine is **internalized** and **incorporated** into an individual's life (eg, behaviors, beliefs). For example, Jewish individuals with a high degree of religiosity demonstrate many beliefs and behaviors that align with Judaism, and "being Jewish" is an important part of how they define themselves.

Observational studies are conducted when it is unethical or unfeasible to manipulate a variable of interest. For example, it would not be feasible (or ethical) to manipulate the degree to which religion is internalized.

Therefore, the survey findings presented are from an *observational study* (ie, no manipulation of variables) that assessed *religiosity*, the incorporation of religion into an individual's life.

(Choices A and B) Religious affiliation describes the specific religious group to which an individual identifies, which is not synonymous with living one's life according to the principles, behaviors, or customs of that religion. For example, one may consider oneself to be Catholic but not attend church. A study in which believers are surveyed about the incorporation of religion into their lives is assessing *religiosity*, not religious affiliation.

(Choices B and D) In an experimental design, the researcher manipulates independent variables to measure their effect on dependent variables. In this study, no variables were manipulated, making it an *observational*, not experimental, design.

Educational objective:

Religious affiliation describes an individual identifying with a specific religious group, whereas religiosity (or religiousness) is the degree to which an individual internalizes and incorporates that religion into their lives, as demonstrated by the individual's behaviors and beliefs.

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Behavioral Sciences

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System:

Demographics and Social Structure

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Based on information in the passage, which of the following best represents a latent function of FBLDs?

- ☐ A. Believers incorporating FBLDs as an expression of their faith [8%]
- ☐ B. Reduction of health disparities in the community [18%]
- ☐ C. Believers founding hospitals and clinics [6%]
- ✓ ☒ D. Lower rates of chronic illnesses in believers who follow FBLDs [66%]

Correct

65% answered correctly

Explanation:

Functionalism: Manifest vs. latent functions	
Manifest functions	Latent functions
Intended, obvious purpose of a social structure (eg, <i>teaching facts and skills is a manifest function of the education system</i>)	Unintended result of a social structure (eg, <i>contributing to social inequality is a latent function of the education system</i>)

Structural functionalism is a macro-sociological perspective that compares modern society to a **biological organism**. This theory proposes that, just as the various organ systems cooperate to maintain an organism's homeostasis, social institutions work together in the interest of societal balance, known as dynamic equilibrium.

From the structural functionalist perspective, social institutions have **manifest functions**, which are **expected**, and **latent functions**, which are **unintended**. For example, social media allows people to keep in touch with friends and family (ie, manifest function), but police departments have used suspect's social media profiles to gather information (ie, latent function).

The passage does not state that religions advocate FBLDs *to reduce the incidence of chronic illness*. Therefore, lower rates of chronic illnesses in believers are unintended, *latent functions* of FBLDs from the functionalism perspective.

(Choices A, B, and C) As described in the passage, the incorporation of FBLDs as an expression of believers' faith, the founding of hospitals and clinics, and the reduction of health disparities in the community are all manifest (ie, expected) directives and consequences of religions with FBLDs and health-related values.

Educational objective:

Structural functionalism is a macro-level sociological perspective proposing that social institutions work together to maintain societal balance (dynamic equilibrium). Social institutions have manifest (intended) functions and latent (unintended) functions.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Demographics and Social Structure